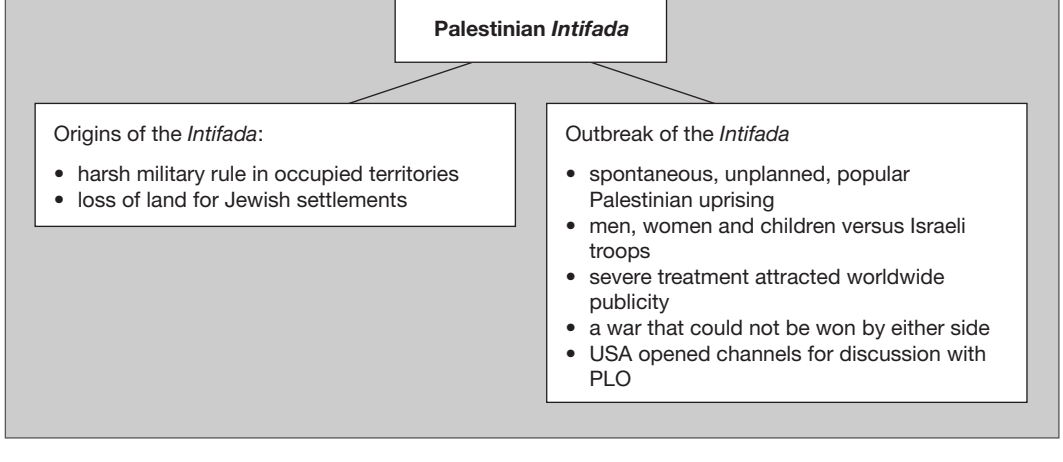
Worldwide publicity was given to the tear-gassing of demonstrators, the beatings of men, women and children, the closing of schools and colleges. The world saw a powerful, modern army let loose against civilians who were fighting for their human rights and the right to govern themselves.

In Israel itself, opinion was divided: some demanded the use of greater force, others recognised that the *Intifada* was a genuinely popular rising and that it could not be put down by military means. An Israeli professor said:

> An army can beat an army, but an army cannot beat a people. Israel is learning that power has limits. Iron can smash iron, it cannot smash an unarmed fist.

Moves towards a peaceful solution

Many Israelis came to see that the *Intifada* was a war that could not be won: some of them believed that there had to be a political solution. Many Palestinians in Gaza and the West Bank came to the same conclusion. The *Intifada* raised their morale and boosted their confidence but it did not improve their miserable living conditions or end the occupation. Palestinian leaders in Gaza and the West Bank realised they had to put pressure on the PLO leaders in Tunisia to recognise Israel and to persuade the Israeli government to accept a Palestinian state.

The role of the USA, Israel's main ally, was crucial. There was much sympathy in America for the Palestinians and many Jewish Americans began to question the methods used by the Israeli forces. The key breakthrough came late in 1988 when the US government recognised the PLO as a necessary partner in any peace negotiations. Up until this time, the USA had refused to have any dealings with the PLO but, when the PLO leaders showed willing to recognise the state of Israel, the Americans changed their policy. The way was now open for the start of what became known as the 'peace process'.

Summary diagram: The Palestinian *Intifada* 1987–93